PADHAKU
Footprints without Feet · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 3

The Midnight Visitor

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Midnight Visitor · Read and Find Out (1) 2 Q

The Midnight Visitor · Read and Find Out (2) 2 Q

The Midnight Visitor · Think about it 3 Q

The Midnight Visitor · Talk about it 2 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ The Midnight Visitor · Read and Find Out (1)

1 **How is Ausable different from other secret agents?**

✔ ANSWER

Ausable did not look like the secret agents in books. He was **very fat**, wheezed when he spoke, and had an **American accent** even after twenty years in Paris.

He lived in a small, gloomy room on the top floor of a French hotel and got only a "prosaic telephone call" instead of mysterious messages. But he was very clever and calm in danger.

2 **Who is Fowler and what is his first authentic thrill of the day?**

✔ ANSWER

Fowler is a **young, romantic writer** who wanted to meet a real secret agent.

His first authentic thrill came when Ausable switched on the light and they saw a man, **Max, standing in the room with a small automatic pistol** in his hand.

⭐ The Midnight Visitor · Read and Find Out (2)

1 How has Max got in?

✔ ANSWER

Max got into Ausable's room with a **passkey** (a key that opens many locks).

2 How does Ausable say he got in?

✔ ANSWER

Ausable says Max got in **through the balcony** under his window. He says it is the second time in a month that someone has entered his room through "that nuisance of a balcony".

🤔 The Midnight Visitor · Think about it

1 **"Ausable did not fit any description of a secret agent Fowler had ever read." What do secret agents in books and films look like, in your opinion? Discuss in groups or in class some stories or movies featuring spies, detectives and secret agents, and compare their appearance with that of Ausable in this story. (You may mention characters from fiction in languages other than English. In English fiction you may have come across Sherlock Holmes, Hercule Poirot, or Miss Marple. Have you watched any movies featuring James Bond?)**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Secret agents in books and films usually look:

- tall, slim, smart and fit, like **James Bond**
- well dressed and attractive, quick in action and good at fighting and shooting
- mysterious; they meet beautiful women, use secret gadgets and face guns and danger

Detectives like **Sherlock Holmes** are thin, sharp-eyed and observant; Hindi fiction has **Byomkesh Bakshi** and **Karamchand**.

Ausable is the opposite: he is very fat, sloppy, wheezes when he speaks and has an American accent. He lives in a dull hotel room. But like great detectives, he has a **sharp mind** and **presence of mind**, and he defeats Max with words, not with a gun. So looks do not decide how clever a person is.

2 **How does Ausable manage to make Max believe that there is a balcony attached to his room? Look back at his detailed description of it. What makes it a convincing story?**

✔ ANSWER

Ausable acts **angry and irritated** and says he will "raise the devil with the management" because this is the **second time in a month** that someone has entered through the balcony.

He gives exact details:

- the room was once part of a large unit, and the next room was the living room
- that room had the balcony, which **extends under his window**
- one can reach it from the **empty room two doors down**; someone did so last month
- the management **promised to block it off** but did not

His real-sounding anger, the small details and his calm manner make the story convincing. Max even says the balcony "might have saved me some trouble". Then the knock at the door, which Ausable says is the police, makes Max hide on the "balcony".

3 **Looking back at the story, when do you think Ausable thought up his plan for getting rid of Max? Do you think he had worked out his plan in detail right from the beginning? Or did he make up a plan taking advantage of events as they happened?**

✔ ANSWER

Ausable thought up his plan **as soon as he saw Max** in his room with a gun. He blinked a few times, sat down and at once started the story of the balcony.

He had **not worked out the plan in detail from the beginning**, because he did not know Max would be there. He **made it up as events happened**: he knew a waiter (Henry) would bring the drink he had ordered, so when the knock came he said it was the police. This scared Max into jumping out of the window onto the balcony that did not exist.

This shows his **presence of mind** and quick thinking.

⭐ The Midnight Visitor · Talk about it

1 **In this story, Ausable shows great 'presence of mind,' or the ability to think quickly, and act calmly and wisely, in a situation of danger and surprise. Give examples from your own experience, or narrate a story, which shows someone's presence of mind.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Example: Last summer my little cousin was alone at home with his grandmother when she suddenly fainted. He did not panic. He turned on the fan, sprinkled water on her face and called our neighbour, a nurse, and then dialled **112** for an ambulance. He also phoned his father. The doctor said help had come just in time.

A story: In the Panchatantra, a monkey is taken across the river by a crocodile who wants to eat his heart. The monkey calmly says he has left his heart on the tree. The foolish crocodile takes him back, and the monkey escapes. His quick thinking saved his life.

2 **Discuss what you would do in the situations described below. Remember that presence of mind comes out of a state of mental preparedness. If you have thought about possible problems or dangers, and about how to act in such situations, you have a better**

chance of dealing with such situations if they do arise.

• A small fire starts in your kitchen.

• A child starts to choke on a piece of food.

• An electrical appliance starts to hiss and gives out sparks.

• A bicycle knocks down a pedestrian.

• It rains continuously for more than twenty-four hours.

• A member of your family does not return home at the usual or expected time.

You may suggest other such situations.

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- **Small fire in the kitchen:** Stay calm, turn off the gas regulator. Cover a pan fire with a lid or a wet cloth; never pour water on oil or electric fires. Use a fire extinguisher or sand. If it spreads, leave the house and call **101**.
- **Child choking:** If the child cannot cough or breathe, give 5 firm back blows between the shoulder blades and then abdominal thrusts (Heimlich manoeuvre). Do not put a finger deep in the mouth. Call **108/112** if it does not come out.
- **Appliance hissing and sparking:** Do not touch it. Switch off the **main switch** (MCB) at once. Keep children away. Get it checked by an electrician.

- **Bicycle hits a pedestrian:** Help the person to a safe side of the road, check for injuries, give first aid and call an ambulance if needed. Inform the family. Keep the crowd calm.
- **Rain for more than 24 hours:** Stay indoors, keep a torch, drinking water, food, medicines and charged phones ready. Switch off power if water enters. Keep away from rivers, drains and electric poles. Follow news and official warnings.
- **Family member late:** Do not panic. Call his/her phone, then friends or the office. Wait a while; if there is still no news, inform the relatives and, if needed, the police (**112**).
- **Another situation – a stranger asks to enter the house when you are alone:** Do not open the door; call a parent or neighbour.

🎉 **Chapter 3 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**